



CVC WORDS SHORT A

Read it • Build it • Write it

One consonant, one short vowel, one consonant. No blends, no digraphs.

1 • short a

2 • short i

3 • short o

4 • short u

5 • short e

bundle • mixed review

What is in this unit

Six practice pages, a ten-word probe, a four-week data sheet, and two pages that turn the scores into next steps. Print once and slide the practice pages into sleeves — students write with a dry-erase marker and the unit lasts all year.

Why the sequence is printed here

So you can slot this into whatever phonics program you already use instead of guessing what it assumes. Short **a** comes first because it appears in more early decodable words than any other short vowel; **e** comes last because **e** and **i** are the pair students most often confuse, and separating them reduces that collision.

Structure follows the IES practice guide's two strong-evidence recommendations for K–3: link speech sounds to letters, and teach students to decode, write and recognise words. Full citation on the last page.

PRACTICE 1 · WITH PICTURES

READ IT. BUILD IT. WRITE IT.

Say the word out loud. Push a letter into each box. Then write it on the line.

READ

BUILD

WRITE



cat

o

o

o

.....



map

o

o

o

.....



sad

o

o

o

.....



pan

o

o

o

.....



bag

o

o

o

.....



hat

o

o

o

.....



Challenge: pick two words and say a whole sentence for each, out loud.

Colour a star for each word you read on your own



Teacher tally

 / 6

Name: _____ Date: _____

Bright Scholar

PRACTICE 2 • NO PICTURE CLUES

READ IT. BUILD IT. WRITE IT.

This time there are no pictures. Sound out each letter, then blend the whole word.

READ

BUILD

WRITE

1 **bat**



.....

2 **jam**



.....

3 **tap**



.....

4 **ran**



.....

5 **mad**



.....

6 **wag**



.....

Write your own

Think of one more word with the short a sound. Write it and draw it.

.....



Teacher note: if a student stalls here but flew through Practice 1, the pictures were doing the decoding. That is worth knowing — mark it on the data sheet.

PRACTICE 3 · SOUND BOXES

TAP THE SOUNDS.

Your teacher says a word. Tap one box for each sound you hear, then write the letter in the box.

TEACHER — say these in order:

can

lap

fan

rat

gas

ham

1

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word

2

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word

3

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word

4

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word

5

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word

6

--	--	--

say the sounds · then write the word



Three boxes, three sounds. Every word in this unit has exactly three.

Teacher note

Tapping the sounds before writing separates two different problems. A student who taps three sounds correctly but writes the wrong letter has a **letter-sound** gap. A student who cannot tap three sounds at all has a **segmenting** gap, and needs the sounds before the spelling. Note which one you saw — the Growth Eval asks.

WHICH WORD MATCHES?

Read the word bank. Write the word that matches each picture on the line underneath it.

WORD BANK

van

fan

jam

rat

can

ham



.....



.....



.....



.....



.....



.....

Finished early? Turn the page over and draw one more short-a thing. Label it.

SORT BY THE ENDING.

Every word below ends in -at, -ap or -ag. Read each one, then write it in the right column.

WORD BANK

cat

map

bag

hat

tap

rag

bat

nap

tag

mat

lap

wag

-AT

.....

.....

.....

.....

-AP

.....

.....

.....

.....

-AG

.....

.....

.....

.....

Four words go in each column. If a column has five, read them again — one is in the wrong place.

Pick one word from each column and say it in a sentence.

.....

READ IT, THEN SHOW IT.

Read each sentence out loud. Circle every short-a word you find. Then draw what it says.

The cat sat on my hat.

Dad had jam in a pan.

A rat ran to the van.

DRAW SENTENCE 1

DRAW SENTENCE 2

DRAW SENTENCE 3

Teacher note: "the", "on", "my", "had", "in", "a", "to" are not short-a CVC words — they are there so the sentence works. Only the circled words are the target.

Now write your own sentence with two short-a words.

.....

.....

READ THESE TEN WORDS.

Point to each word and read it out loud. Your teacher will listen and mark their own sheet — you just read.

cat**map****sad****pan****bag****hat****tap****rag****jam****van**

TEACHER: give no prompts and no sounding-out help during the probe. Mark a word correct only if the student reads it accurately within about three seconds. Record on the data sheet, then use the Growth Eval.

DATE

.....

WEEK

.....

SCORE

— / 10

UNIT 1 PROBE • DATA SHEET

Ten words, read aloud, once a week. Circle each one read correctly. Score out of 10, then take the score to the Growth Eval.

Probe word	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4
cat	☐	☐	☐	☐
map	☐	☐	☐	☐
sad	☐	☐	☐	☐
pan	☐	☐	☐	☐
bag	☐	☐	☐	☐
hat	☐	☐	☐	☐
tap	☐	☐	☐	☐
rag	☐	☐	☐	☐
jam	☐	☐	☐	☐
van	☐	☐	☐	☐
Score / 10	_____	_____	_____	_____

What did you notice? (the eval page uses this)

Which sound slipped • speed or accuracy • did the miss change week to week • did they self-correct

.....

.....

Move-on signal: 8 of 10 across two probes in a row. Mastery criteria in phonics commonly sit at 80–90% accuracy; we ask for 80% twice rather than 90% once, so a single good day does not look like mastery.

AI GROWTH EVAL • one STUDENT

Find the score from the data sheet. Read across. No technology needed for any of this.

0-4

The sound is not secure yet.

- Drop back to letter-sound work with just **a** — three minutes daily.
- Use the sound-box page before the writing pages.
- Re-probe in one week with the same ten words.

5-7

Blending is emerging but not automatic.

- Stay in the unit; keep the Build-It step rather than jumping to writing.
- Compare Practice 1 and Practice 2 — if only the no-picture page slipped, the pictures were decoding for them.
- Re-probe in one week; move at 8 twice in a row.

8-10

Short a is solid. Move.

- Start Unit 2 (short i); keep short a alive in mixed review.
- Spot-check short a again in three weeks.

OPTIONAL • IF YOU USE AN AI ASSISTANT

"I teach 2nd grade. A student scored 6 out of 10 on a short-vowel CVC probe. The misses were all words ending in -g and -m, and they self-corrected twice. Give me three specific next steps for this week and one way to check whether it worked."

Describe the grade and the pattern — never a name, never a class list. The student never uses the tool.

Honest limits: ten words is a signal, not a diagnosis. Use it to choose this week's move, alongside everything else you know about the reader.

GROUP SNAPSHOT • WHO NEEDS WHAT

Record the group by student number — S1, S2, S3 — not by name. The pattern across the group tells you how to split your minutes next week.

Student	Score /10	Which words missed	Group
S1	---	-----	---
S2	---	-----	---
S3	---	-----	---
S4	---	-----	---
S5	---	-----	---
S6	---	-----	---

Re-teach

0–4 • daily sound work

Practise

5–7 • stay in unit

Move on

8–10 twice • next unit

OPTIONAL • LET AI DO THE SORTING

"Here are short-vowel CVC probe scores for a 2nd-grade group, out of 10, with the words each one missed. S1: 6 (bag, rag, jam, van). S2: 9 (jam). S3: 7 (bag, rag, jam). S4: 6 (rag, jam, bag, van). S5: 9 (rag). S6: 4 (bag, rag, jam, van, sad, hat). Group them into re-teach / practise / move on, tell me the sound pattern most of the group is missing, and suggest how to split 20 minutes of small-group time across the three groups tomorrow."

Student numbers only — S1, S2, S3. No names, no initials, nothing about the child beyond the score and the words missed.

Why this works: the words each student missed carry more information than the score. In the example above, five of six students read cat, map, pan, sad, hat and tap correctly and missed bag, rag or jam — the vowel is the same in every one of those words, so short a is not the problem. The final sounds -g and -m are. That is a fifteen-minute lesson, not a re-teach of the whole unit.

HOW THIS UNIT IS BUILT

What we based it on, what we are claiming, and what we are not.

The instructional structure

Each unit links speech sounds to letters and then asks the student to decode, build and write the same words. That mirrors the two **strong-evidence** recommendations in the IES / What Works Clearinghouse practice guide for K–3 foundational skills: *"Develop awareness of the segments of sounds in speech and how they link to letters"* and *"Teach students to decode words, analyze word parts, and write and recognize words."*

The 8-of-10 move-on signal

Mastery criteria in phonics commonly sit between 80% and 100% accuracy, with 90% often cited. We ask for 80% on two consecutive probes rather than 90% once, because repeating the criterion is what separates a good day from a secure skill. Adjust it to match whatever your school already uses — the data sheet works either way.

What we are not claiming

This unit is not aligned to, affiliated with, or a substitute for any named phonics program, and it is not a diagnostic assessment. It is practice material and a ten-word progress check. Every target word in this unit is a true short-a CVC word — one consonant, one short vowel, one consonant — with no blends or digraphs, verified by an automated check before publication, so the probe measures the one thing it says it measures.

References

Foorman, B., Beyler, N., Borradaile, K., Coyne, M., Denton, C. A., Dimino, J., Furgeson, J., Hayes, L., Henke, J., Justice, L., Keating, B., Lewis, W., Sattar, S., Streke, A., Wagner, R., & Wissel, S. (2016). *Foundational skills to support reading for understanding in kindergarten through 3rd grade* (NCEE 2016-4008). National Center for Education Evaluation and Regional Assistance, Institute of Education Sciences, U.S. Department of Education. Revised December 2019.

Phonics Hero. *Mastery in phonics learning*. — summary of criterion levels used in phonics research (80–100%, with 90% most commonly cited).

Built and audited by two certified teachers. Unit 2 (short i) follows. If you find an error in any word list or probe, message us through TPT and we will fix it and re-upload the same day — you keep the updated file free.